

Verify-First — Researcher Quick Reference

A safe, simple way to use AI in your research. Print this and keep it near your desk.

Three rules, every time

1. **You are the author.** AI drafts; you are accountable for every word that goes out under your name.
2. **Verify everything specific.** Check every fact, number, quotation, and citation against a primary source — not against the AI's own restatement of it.
3. **Protect the data.** Never put anything non-public (unpublished proposals, manuscripts under review, sponsor or occupant data, student records) into a consumer AI tool. Use an institutional privacy-safe tool instead.

Which tool for which data

If the material is...	Use...
Public (published papers, public web text)	Any approved tool
Non-public (unpublished, confidential, personal)	An institutional privacy-safe tool only
Protected student records	An approved tool only, and de-identify first

Before anything leaves your hands

- [] Did I check every fact, number, and citation against a real source?
- [] Did any confidential data go only to an approved tool?
- [] Would I stand behind this if asked, as its author?
- [] Have I disclosed AI assistance where the venue or policy requires it?

When *not* to use AI

When you cannot verify the output · when the data is confidential and no approved tool is available · when the task is one you are still learning and need to build the skill yourself.

Verify-First — One-Page Checklist for Advisors

Why this matters for your lab. AI can genuinely speed up literature work, coding, and drafting — but it also fabricates facts and citations, and it can leak confidential data. A single unchecked number or invented reference in a proposal or paper is a credibility risk that lands on the whole group.

The one norm to reinforce: *verify before it ships*. Your researchers should treat every AI-produced fact, number, and citation as unverified until checked against a primary source.

A 30-second check before a student's draft goes out

- [] Ask: "Which of these facts and citations did you verify against the original source?"
- [] Spot-check one or two specific numbers or references yourself.
- [] Confirm no confidential data went into a non-approved tool.

How to make it stick

- Name the expectation explicitly in your group.
- Model it on your own drafts.
- Treat "I verified this" as a normal, expected part of handing work in.